



“We have a portfolio of 19 brands, but they are unique in their own way. There is no cross-contamination of brands. They have their own swimming lanes and remain very different”

business of generating fees. It's about building partnerships and relationships.

Q: How critical are considerations of heterogeneity across markets for brand positioning?

A: A lot of local and cultural opportunities drive hotel design and experience. This means an InterContinental can be different in terms of architectural design or food experience to reflect the local culture. So, arrival experience, reception, team members will change. Take Six Senses, where the spa experience changes across locations, because it has to be specific to the environment.

But the basic values remain the same and what we deliver by way of brand promise and quality standards is always intact. So is the way the team is selected.

Or the quality of bedding and linen. The aura around the hotel experience has to be the same because you have to feel like you are staying in an InterContinental property regardless of the location. It is that heritage that you feel throughout. The touch points for each guest have to always remind them that they are at an InterContinental—whether it's the scent, the linen or the material they touch. The people who work in hospitality are like ambassadors and travel around the world. It's almost like an exchange programme for students.

The look and feel changes—that could be the colours or the artwork—to reflect the location, but brand hallmarks remain. Sleeping on the bed is a good example, because regardless of where I am, that experience is absolutely the same.

Q: Do you want to pick up one or two examples of markets where the industry's evolution took place much sooner than anticipated?

A: Most of my experiences come from Gulf region countries and countries that feed these markets. That has given me a good understanding of the eastern European market as it is a big outbound market, especially for Dubai and the Middle East.

Even if you look at smaller countries such as Jordan, there is a wealth of natural assets. It also has historical and religious sites. Its tourism has relied heavily on the US market. In the past, more specifically around 15 years ago, anything that happened in the US or the Middle East led to slowing down (of tourism). At that point, the average American looked at the Middle East as one country and not 28 countries. A lot has changed, and more Americans now want to travel to Dubai or Delhi or Agra.